# MISS MARVEL

## TAAPSEE PANNU, 34

*Actor*

The best of actors resist being pigeonholed, but Taapsee Pannu seems to thrive in the image she's been boxed in, as someone who prefers woman-centred, empowering narratives. "The only stereotype I don't mind is that the film has a *tedha* [crooked] heroine or has some takeaway," says Pannu. "I don't want to repeat the *muddle* [issues]."

It all started with *Pink* in which she shone as a sexual assault survivor fighting the system. Since then, Taapsee has made a career out of playing messy, strong women (*Badla*, *Manmarziyaan*, *Haseen Dillruba*) persevering against all odds (*Saand ki Aankh*, *Game Over*, *Thappad*; *Rashmi Rocket*). Still, it's not what she consciously set out to do. "I didn't have an option," she says. "I was never seen as a conventional heroine. It was the only route left."

Taapsee was also one of the first actors to embrace streaming platforms with enthusiasm, with three releases in 2021. She has also made it a point to shuttle between Hindi cinema and the South, where she first got a break. Her work calendar is packed, but she is still awaiting that one super role. "I want to be Captain Marvel," she says. ■

*–Suhani Singh*

**GREEN THUMB** Taapsee loves gardening and has around 200 plants at her duplex in Mumbai where she also grows vegetables



*Photograph by* **BANDEEP SINGH**